was a disciplinary case like them, banished to the boondocks. Something like our equivalent of the French Foreign Legion.

I used this analogy in my first Sainik Sammelan, my address to the troops. We were strangers to each other, except for the few 'stalwarts' from my own Lucky Seven. At the outset, I told them that I was donning the mantle of CO 2 RR, not CO 7 SIKH LI. Each one of them was equally dear to me irrespective of which arm and service they came from. There would be no favouritism; this last was more directed towards my 'boys' from Seven: they should not expect any special treatment. Finally, I told them that the past is the past, no questions asked, and that I would judge them solely on their performance in 2 RR and their loyalty to our unit. That we were all part of a bright new team with a bright new future. This was an opportunity for them to chart a new course and on completion of their deputation, return to their parent units with their heads held high, perhaps even with a gallantry award to boot.

Over the next few days as I visited each Company in turn, I could feel that the men were weighing me up to see whether I would 'walk the talk'. I went with each Company for a planned ambush or area domination patrol (ADP) led by the Company Commander, both by day and night. This allowed me to gauge the standards of each Company as well as the Company Commander himself. Also, the battle procedures and battle drills, and what more needed to be done to improve operational effectiveness. I did not interfere in the conduct at all but participated as an observer, just another member of the patrol. The only time I did intervene was on one occasion when I knew that we had gone off-course and were heading in the wrong direction. How did I know? Because I had made the same mistake in navigation as a young Lieutenant in the deserts of Rajasthan, of not trusting your compass. Experience and lessons learnt the hard way.

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